

THE SUBTLE ART OF NOT GIVING A F*CK

A Counterintuitive Approach to Living a Good Life

MARK MANSON

The Big “So What”



Today, people enjoy more material wealth and comforts, yet tend to feel more impoverished emotionally and psychologically. **This book offers insights and tips to help us cope with our pain, failures and regrets, so we can live fully and find genuine happiness.**

Introduction



We are constantly bombarded by messages about becoming happier, healthier, smarter, and richer. We buy more things, tips and experiences, hoping to improve our image, happiness level and satisfaction. Yet, **in the pursuit of more, we end up losing sight of what we already have, and reinforce our sense of lack.**

Manson explains why our modern values—like success, positivity, greatness, and freedom—can actually make us more insecure and miserable. The way to be happy and fulfilled, he says, is to not give a f*ck about everything we’re told to care about. Instead, **get clear on what truly matters, focus your choices on those few priorities, and accept that in spite of that, you’ll still make stupid mistakes and suffer occasionally.**

In this summary, we’ll present the key ideas in 2 parts:

- Debunking modern myths on success and happiness; and
- Embracing the 5 counterintuitive values for a good life

KEY QUOTES

“This book will turn your pain into a tool, your trauma into power, and your problems into slightly better problems.”

“We are so materially well off, yet so psychologically tormented in so many low-level and shallow ways.”

“The key to a good life is not giving a fuck about more; it’s giving a fuck about less, giving a fuck about only what is true and immediate and important.”

Debunking Myths on Success and Happiness



Stop Trying

Why do people feel unhappy and depressed despite having more choices and material success?



The paradox is this: the more you pursue the positives, the more negative you'll feel and vice versa:

- The more you chase after the positives, the worse you'll feel. Those who desperately want to be rich, worthy or happy tend to feel poorer, more unworthy or unhappy, no matter how much they already have in life.
- On the other hand, the more you accept the negatives in your life, the better you'll feel. Embracing your failures makes you wiser, accepting your flaws makes you more authentic, and facing your fears gives you more confidence.



We're surrounded by messages about why we should overcome our negative feelings and feel good about ourselves—so much so that we tend to feel bad for feeling bad. Manson calls this the "feedback loop from hell".

- Imagine you're angry about a mistake you've made. You become angry with yourself for dwelling on your mistake (since you know you should be positive), and you're now angry about feeling angry. It doesn't help that the TV, internet and social media are full of amazing stories and images of people who've rebounded from failures and are now living happy, perfect lives. So now you feel doubly bad for feeling bad, and the negative loop continues.
- The way to stop this feedback loop is to stop giving a f*ck about everything or trying to be perfect. Realize that shortcomings and bad feelings are perfectly normal, and stop fretting over them.

KEY QUOTES

"Our crisis is no longer material; it's existential, it's spiritual. We have so much fucking stuff and so many opportunities that we don't even know what to give a fuck about anymore."

"The more you pursue a positive experience, the more negative you feel. The more you accept a negative experience, the more positive you feel."

"These moments of non-fuckery are the moments that most define our lives."



However, this doesn't mean that you should become indifferent to everything. There are 3 nuances to not giving a f*ck:

- Don't give a f*ck about conventional norms and others' opinions. Dare to be *different*, be it making that scary career switch which everyone advises against, or leaving that abusive spouse.
- Don't give a f*ck about pain and adversity. You can't expect to make real breakthroughs while avoiding challenges and failures. Figure out what's truly important, what's worthy of your time and energy, and give a f*ck about *that* above all else—including your pain and fears.
- People who claim they don't care about anything are actually hiding behind a mask of indifference to avoid making tough choices in life. You have to give a f*ck about something, so choose your priorities carefully. Don't waste time and energy on things that don't matter, e.g. the rude waiter, your colleague getting promoted over you, or missing a great bargain. Decide what you do care about, go all out for it, and be prepared to put aside everything else, including others' opinions and the risk of failure.



Pain isn't bad



Pain is your friend. Pain is a part of our biological feedback system to spur us into action.

- It's not something bad to be avoided, but a tool to tell us something needs our attention. *Physical pain* warns us of possible danger (e.g. a hot stove or a knife blade), while *psychological pain* tells us that something is out of balance.
- Pain and suffering are an integral part of human existence. No one can avoid them, e.g. the rich suffer due to their riches while the poor suffer due to their poverty. Since pain is inevitable, trying to avoid it will only bring more pain. Instead, learn to accept it and let it go.

KEY QUOTES

"Not giving a fuck does not mean being indifferent; it means being comfortable with being different."

"To not give a fuck is to stare down life's most terrifying and difficult challenges and still take action."

"The point isn't to get away from the shit. The point is to find the shit you enjoy dealing with."

"Our own pain and misery aren't a bug of human evolution; they're a feature... Pain, in all of its forms, is our body's most effective means of spurring action."



In fact, happiness doesn't come from being problem-free. Happiness comes from solving meaningful problems.

- Everyone has problems, and new problems will keep surfacing. In fact, your solution to one problem often creates even more problems. For example, you may buy a gym membership to overcome the inertia to exercise, but now you must make time to go to the gym. The person you love and marry is likely to be the person you quarrel with the most. Your dream job is also likely to give you the most challenges and sleepless nights. So, the key is to find meaningful problems that you'll enjoy solving.
- When we deny/avoid our problems or tell ourselves they can't be solved, we feel miserable. Many people also distract themselves with temporary highs like alcohol or adventures. The longer you avoid your problems, the more painful it will be when you eventually face them.



Treat your emotions as signposts. Our feelings are biological signals to tell us what's working or not working. However, emotions are not always accurate and they don't last. Hence, don't suppress your emotions, over-identify with them, nor make decisions based on emotions alone.



All of us want positive feelings and outcomes, but we don't stop to consider the pain and struggles needed to achieve those outcomes. Rather than focusing only on the outcomes you'd enjoy, ask yourself: What pain and struggles might you enjoy and sustain? For example, will you enjoy the pain of training for a triathlon, or the uncertainties of entrepreneurship? By identifying what you're willing to endure, you can fall in love not just with the reward but also the process.



You're not special

Everywhere we turn, we hear writers, speakers and experts telling us that we're unique and destined for greatness. We're surrounded daily by extreme stories about the biggest, grandest, fastest, richest people or events. These stories are crafted to grab our attention, and they also create dangerous perspectives that extremes are the norm, and being average is a sign of failure.

KEY QUOTES

"The secret sauce is in the solving of the problems, not in not having problems in the first place."

"Problems never stop; they merely get exchanged and/or upgraded."

"Emotions...(are) feedback mechanisms telling us that something is either likely right or likely wrong for us—nothing more, nothing less."

"You can't win if you don't play."

"Our struggles determine our successes."

"This flood of extreme information has conditioned us to believe that exceptionalism is the new normal."



In reality, most of us are average. Even if we excel in 1 area, we're usually average or below average in other areas. When people have unrealistic expectations of what's "normal", they (a) feel insecure/inadequate and try to overcompensate by pursuing get-rich-quick schemes, taking extreme actions, voicing radical views, and/or (b) develop an inflated sense of self-importance and a false sense of entitlement.



People who achieve extraordinary results don't start by expecting to be great, or feeling entitled/special. They accept that they're average and the bulk of the work they do will be mundane and inconsequential. They focus on improving themselves day after day, rather than pretending to be the next big thing when they're not. In the process, they learn to appreciate the small pleasures of learning, solving problems, helping others, and connecting with friends and loved ones.



Likewise, when we believe our challenges are unique, we tend to feel as if the world owes us something. In reality, everyone goes through trauma in life—be it parental divorce, a bad accident, or a major betrayal. Having challenges doesn't make you privileged or entitled in any way. There are many others who face similar, if not worse, challenges than you, and have taken concrete steps to deal with them.



Suffer Purposefully

Throughout history, humans have willingly suffered for causes they believe in—be it voyaging to discover distant lands or waging war for the glory of an empire. Since suffering is inevitable, the question we should be asking isn't how we can end our suffering, but for what *purpose* are we suffering.



We gain self-awareness in layers:

- 1st level: Understand what emotion you're feeling, e.g. angry, sad, or happy. Learn to overcome your emotional blind spots, or the emotions you've been taught to ignore.
- 2nd level: Understand why you're feeling that way. It may take months or years to uncover the root causes.

KEY QUOTES

"The Internet has not just open-sourced information; it has also open-sourced insecurity, self-doubt, and shame."

"The ticket to emotional health...comes from... accepting the bland and mundane truths of life."

"The easier and more problem-free our lives become, the more we seem to feel entitled for them to get even better."

"Self-awareness is like an onion. There are multiple layers to it, and the more you peel them back, the more likely you're going to start crying at inappropriate times."

"Our values determine the nature of our problems, and the nature of our problems determines the quality of our lives."

- 3rd level: Understand your personal values, which affect what you define as success or failure, how you measure/judge yourself and others, and what you do or don't do. This is the most important but difficult layer to peel open, because you must get uncomfortable and be honest with yourself.



Many self-help tips focus on the first 2 levels of awareness. However, fundamental change occurs at the 3rd level—when you change your values, you change how you view success and failure in life.

- After Dave Mustaine was kicked out of Metallica, he went on to form a new band and became massively successful in his music career. Yet, 20 years later, he still felt like a failure for being thrown out of his former band. By contrast, Pete Best was kicked out of The Beatles and never rebuilt his music career. However, he met his wife, built a loving family, and believed he was much happier than he would've been if he had stayed with The Beatles. Both men faced similar setbacks, but took different actions and evaluated their lives differently because they held different values.
- Most of us instinctively use money and status to measure ourselves against others, but these are not the only yardsticks we can use. The next time you feel troubled, examine the underlying reasons and values behind your feelings, and consider if you could re-evaluate the situation using better values or metrics.



Good and bad values. Manson says that good values should meet 3 criteria: be (a) based on facts, (b) socially-constructive and (c) immediate and controllable. Bad values are the opposite.

- Good, healthy values are intrinsic and fully within your control since you can always shift your attitude or perspective. Examples include: honesty, innovation, respect for self and others, curiosity, and humility.
- Bad, unhealthy values are extrinsic and are thus not fully within your control. Common examples include:
 - (a) *Pleasure*: It provides short-term, superficial satisfaction but brings emptiness in the long-run.

KEY QUOTES

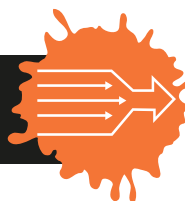
(b) *Material success*: Research found that material success improves happiness only insofar as it helps people to meet their basic needs (e.g. food and shelter). Once those needs are met, additional wealth has almost no impact on happiness.

(c) *Being right*: This only prevents you from acknowledging your flaws and learning from your mistakes.

(d) *Staying positive*: It's unhealthy to focus only on the positives. Acknowledging the negatives is the only way to address our problems to generate happiness.

In short, self-improvement is really about identifying better values, prioritizing them, and learning not to give a f*ck about what doesn't matter.

The 5 Counterintuitive Values for a Good Life



Take radical responsibility



When you take responsibility for your problems, you gain power over them.

- When you feel that you're forced to face a problem, or blame others for your unhappiness, you feel victimized and miserable. You miss the fact that only you can control your emotions, and stop considering how you may have contributed to the situation. On the other hand, when you *choose* to tackle a problem, you can actively look for solutions and thus feel empowered and energized.
- Imagine that your business partner has just cheated you of \$1mil. You can choose to feel helpless and depressed, or feel motivated to turn things around. You can blame everything on your partner and bad luck, or you can acknowledge that you failed to identify the tell-tale signs and do your due-diligence.

KEY QUOTES

"Constant positivity is a form of avoidance, not a valid solution to life's problems."

"When you give better fucks, you get better problems. And when you get better problems, you get a better life."

"Often the only difference between a problem being painful or being powerful is a sense that we chose it, and that we are responsible for it."



You're always choosing. Even though you can't control what happens around you, you can *always* control how to interpret these events and how you respond (or not respond) to them. Even saying "I have no choice" or "there's nothing I can do" is in itself a choice.

- Even when life deals you a bad hand (e.g. being born with deficiencies, losing a loved one), you can choose how to react. No matter how severe your setback, there's always someone else who've been dealt a worse hand and made something out of his her circumstances.
- Responsibility vs Fault. We love to take credit for success, yet we avoid responsibility for problems because we wrongly associate responsibility with fault. Taking responsibility for a problem will not put you at fault, e.g. a judge is responsible for judging a murder case, even though he's not at fault for the murder.
- When we criticize others and complain about how offended we are, it feels good because we seem to be on moral high ground. However, in the process, (a) we forget that democracy is about respecting diverse viewpoints, and (b) we get so distracted by the trivialities that we lose sight of the truly important issues.



Making the shift. The next time you find yourself feeling offended, victimized or self-righteous, stop to consider if the issue really matters. If not, choose to let it go and focus on something more meaningful. It will take time to figure out what values really matter to you, but it's never too late to start today.



Embrace Uncertainty



Test your assumptions. Much of what we consider to be "universal truths" could actually be wrong. Mankind once believed that diseases could be cured by draining bad blood, and that the sun revolved around Earth. At some point, all of us were also absolutely certain about something that turned out to be totally wrong.

- Success and learning fall on a spectrum. You don't move from failure to success, or from wrong to right. You move from less successful to more successful, from wrong to less wrong.

KEY QUOTES

"The more we choose to accept responsibility in our lives, the more power we will exercise over our lives."

"Growth is an endlessly iterative process...We are always in the process of approaching truth and perfection without actually ever reaching truth or perfection."

- There's no "right" ideology or viewpoint. Our values and beliefs are formed from our subjective interpretation of the limited experiences we have. Over time, we each form different views on the meaning of life and the best way to live. Since all of us have different experiences, we'll also have different perspectives and conclusions about life.
- The only way to grow is to realize that your values and beliefs aren't absolute—they can always change or be proven wrong. Don't insist on being right, or cling on to beliefs like "I'm not smart enough", "no one will like me". Treat them as assumptions to be tested.



Don't trust your brain. Research shows that the human brain is highly prone to biases, mistakes, and imperfect memories.

- To help us understand the world, our brain constantly creates associations between cues and experiences. However, it may misinterpret cues ("he's up to no good because he keeps staring at her bag"), or see imaginary patterns ("I'm getting X because I do Y"). Once we form a conclusion or bias, we tend to subconsciously dismiss cues that're inconsistent with our beliefs or recall only details that support our biases/feelings.
- Our brains also don't remember things perfectly. Each time we recall something, we tend to fill in the gaps with our own imagination, e.g. using images from the TV or internet. Over time, our memories can become distorted. We may even invent memories of events that never happened.



The dangers of absolute certainty. When we're absolutely sure about something, we feel insecure if things don't turn out as expected. We start to justify that it's ok to cheat, take what's rightly ours, or dish out punishment that others deserve.

- Psychologist Roy Baumeister found that people who do bad/evil things tend to feel fully justified in their actions, e.g. they believe they have the right to rape women or torture people.
- On the other hand, when we embrace uncertainty, we feel more comfortable about our ignorance and no longer feel the need to judge others and ourselves. The first step to learning and solving problems is to accept that your current priorities, values, beliefs and actions may be wrong—only then can you consider potentially better alternatives.

KEY QUOTES

"Many people become so obsessed with being "right" about their life that they never end up actually living it."

"We're in a perpetual state of misleading ourselves and others for no other reason than that our brain is designed to be efficient, not accurate."

"Evil people never believe that they are evil; rather, they believe that everyone else is evil."

"The only way to solve our problems is to first admit that our actions and beliefs up to this point have been wrong and are not working."



A related concept, Manson's Law of Avoidance, says that we'll avoid things that threaten our self-identity, e.g. avoid risks to protect an image of infallibility, or stay in a painful relationship to prove that we're steadfast.

- Instead of limiting yourself to a certain self-identity, tell yourself that you're still discovering who you are, so you stay humble and open-minded.
- Define yourself in the broadest, simplest way (e.g. a friend, a creator, a father) so your identity is less likely to be threatened, and you're less likely to feel special and entitled.



Learn to ask yourself 3 questions: (a) "What if I'm wrong?" (b) "What would it *mean* if I were wrong?" and (c) "Would being wrong create a better or a worse problem for both myself and others?"



Fail Forward



Your values and beliefs determine how you approach life, e.g. you may have a greater fear of failure if you seek to be well-liked (compared to if you seek to improve your relationships). Go for process-oriented values that allow you to embrace failure. Generally, the longer you've failed at something, the more improvements you'll make and the greater your eventual success or mastery.



Accept pain (e.g. anxiety, fear, sadness) as an essential part of psychological growth.

- At the lowest points in our lives, we're often forced to question why we're failing and to consider what we must do to move forward. That's why people who've overcome great suffering and pain (e.g. warfare) tend to feel more grateful, confident and grounded.
- Pain can make simple questions (e.g. "How do I say no"?) seem difficult and complex. In reality, we're held back by underlying fears (e.g. fear of rejection, fear of letting down our loved ones). Remember that these are merely assumptions, and you won't know if they're true unless you put them to the test.

KEY QUOTES

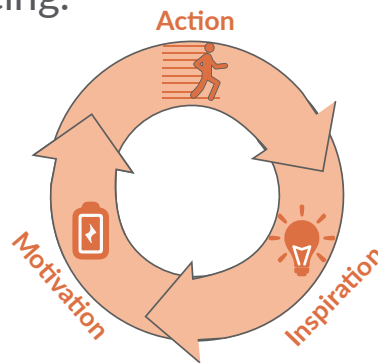
"Being able to look at and evaluate different values without necessarily adopting them is perhaps the central skill required in changing one's own life in a meaningful way."

"We can be truly successful only at something we're willing to fail at."



If you're stuck, just start doing something (anything), and you may find new ideas and answers surfacing.

- You don't always need motivation to drive action. When you take action, you'll trigger the 3-part cycle of action, inspiration and motivation.



- To overcome the fear of failure, don't define success based on end-results. Define success as the act of taking action.



Get comfortable with rejection



Freedom through commitment. Many of us have been conditioned by our consumerist culture to believe that it's better to have more.

- While it's rewarding to enjoy diverse experiences, it can be equally (if not more) fulfilling to focus on a few priorities that matter. Commitment frees you from trivialities and allows you to dive deeper into what's most meaningful (e.g. deepening a relationship or mastering a craft).
- Psychologists found that having too many choices can reduce our level of happiness, because we end up wondering what we missed out. We also get diminishing satisfaction from excessive indulgence (e.g. your 100th house or holiday will be much less exciting than your first few).
- Choosing your priorities. In order to commit to a relationship, career, craft or value, we must be willing to reject something else. Ultimately, our choices—including what we choose to reject or commit to—will define who we are.



To build healthy relationships, it's vital to establish trust and boundaries. This requires both parties to be able to say and hear the word "no".

- In unhealthy relationships, people use one another to escape their own problems, or they try to "fix" others so they can feel good about themselves. They may expect others to take responsibility for their problems (e.g. a husband asking his wife

KEY QUOTES

"Action isn't just the effect of motivation; it's also the cause of it."

"Breadth of experience is likely necessary and desirable when you're young...But depth is where the gold is buried."

"More is not always better...We are actually often happier with less."

"When our highest priority is to always make ourselves feel good, or to always make our partner feel good, then nobody ends up feeling good."

not to go out with her friends because he feels insecure), or they may take responsibility for others' problems (e.g. pretending to agree with a friend so she won't feel rejected). When the goal of a relationship is to make yourself or your partner feel good, it'll result in pretense and manipulation, and things eventually fall apart.

- Healthy relationships come with strong boundaries—each party accepts full responsibility for his/her own values and problems. For example, a husband may acknowledge his insecurities and ask his wife for support to work through it.
- When trust has been broken, it can only be rebuilt with 2 things: (a) the trust-breaker must truly examine and identify the underlying values behind the breach of trust (e.g. need for validation, lack of control), and (b) be willing to change and prove it through action.



Contemplate your mortality



Many ancient philosophers have advocated the practice of contemplating death—it helps us to put our adversities in context and to appreciate life. People who fear death will not dare to live fully, while those who've confronted their mortality will become free to live each day to the fullest.



Ponder about your death and ask yourself: How will the world be different when you're gone? What is your legacy? How will you leave the world a better place?

- If you believe that the universe revolves around you, that you're entitled to greatness, suffering all the injustices, and/or need to amass a huge legacy so you won't be forgotten, you'll constantly feel the need to prove yourself and be plagued by fears of rejection, failure and death.
- However, if you can accept your life as a passing grain in the timeline of the universe, and focus on contributing to a wider cause that outlives you, you'll find true happiness. Make peace with death and make each living moment count—to discover yourself and live fully with no inhibition or shame.

KEY QUOTES

"Trust is like a china plate... If you break it more and more times, eventually it shatters to the point where it's impossible to restore."

"By spending the majority of my short life avoiding what was painful and uncomfortable, I had essentially been avoiding being alive at all."

"The only way to be comfortable with death is... to choose values that stretch beyond serving yourself, that are simple and immediate and controllable and tolerant of the chaotic world around you. This is the basic root of all happiness."